NERAI Maritime Weekly (Corrected)

The week's most consequential events, selected by strategic consequence and grounded in a 103-article 7-day corpus plus live NERAI data.

THE WEEK IN BRIEF - The week of 10-17 August 2026 was dominated by compounding pressure at the Strait of Hormuz and in the Gulf of Oman: drone attacks on tankers, the expiry of the US-Iran ceasefire MOU, and a shadow-fleet spill that satellite analysis now puts above 2,000 sq km on the Omani coast - five times the officially reported extent. Hormuz transits fell sharply and the NY Fed GSCPI stands at 1.769 sigma (93rd percentile). In the Red Sea, a Houthi attack killed four crew and two rescuers, while Saudi crude loadings at Yanbu switched off their AIS transponders. That last development is a loss of visibility rather than a stoppage - loadings continue, but tracking firms' volume estimates now diverge by nearly a factor of three, so the corridor has become difficult to underwrite rather than impossible to use. Russia meanwhile escalated its rhetoric against European navies enforcing shadow-fleet seizures. The common thread is not closure but opacity: in three of these five events the authoritative number is now contested, and clients should treat single-source figures this month as provisional.

01 US–Iran Ceasefire MOU Expires; Hormuz Shipping Falls Sharply

WHY IT RANKS - The expiry of the US–Iran ceasefire MOU, coinciding with a documented sharp drop in Hormuz transits, is the most consequential single development of the week for global energy markets, shipping insurance, and geopolitical stability.

On 17 August 2026, the US–Iran ceasefire MOU was reported to be set to expire amid ongoing tensions, with peace talks described as having stalled. Shipping data tracked by Kepler and reported on 17 August showed Hormuz transits slowing sharply, following an earlier report on 11 August that Strait of Hormuz traffic had dropped to seven ships as US–Iran deal hopes faded. A CNN live-news update on 15 August noted Trump stating he 'did the right thing' and would 'never apologize,' signalling no imminent diplomatic reset. Oil prices edged higher on 17 August, with markets attributing the move directly to the stalled peace talks and Hormuz shipping slowdown.

STRATEGIC ANALYSIS - The lapse of the ceasefire MOU removes a critical de-escalation mechanism and raises the probability of renewed direct military exchanges in the Gulf, a scenario the NERAI Strait of Hormuz corridor already reflects with an escalation score of 36.5 and a news score of 78.0 — the highest news score of any monitored corridor. A sustained drop in Hormuz transits to single-digit daily vessel counts would threaten roughly 20% of global oil flows, triggering spot-market dislocations and a structural repricing of war-risk premiums for Gulf-routed cargoes. India's government response is already visible: PM Modi used his 15 August Independence Day speech to stress energy resilience and the 'Samudra Manthan' project, and Indian refiners were instructed on 17 August to boost domestic LPG output as Hormuz uncertainty lingers. Asian refiners are simultaneously being pushed toward US LPG as a substitute, a demand shift that reshapes Pacific trade flows. Two distinct positions on transit fees have been conflated in wider coverage and are separated here: JPMorgan analysts observed that charges for passage through narrow waters have precedents - Denmark, Sweden and Turkey - which is an observation about legal precedent, not an endorsement; separately, shipowner associations have warned that a Hormuz toll could set a precedent for transit fees at other chokepoints. That is a warning from industry about a risk, not a bank's forecast of a new global standard, and NERAI does not carry the claim that any institution has predicted Hormuz charging will become the model for all energy chokepoints. What the precedent argument does support is that a fee regime, once established, is legally defensible and therefore hard to reverse - which is why it belongs in structural rather than episodic risk. The NERAI sanctions score for Hormuz at 80.0 — the highest of any corridor — underscores the compliance burden already weighing on legitimate operators transiting the strait.

NERAI SIGNAL - Strait of Hormuz: escalation 36.5, news 78.0, sanctions 80.0 — all three metrics elevated simultaneously, consistent with a corridor under acute multi-dimensional stress.

Sources: wsfcam.iheart.com: https://wsfcam.iheart.com/content/2026-08-17-us-iran-ceasefire-mou-set-to-expire-amid-tensions/ | khaama.com: https://www.khaama.com/shipping-through-strait-of-hormuz-slows-sharply-kepler-data-shows/ | thenationalnews.com: https://www.thenationalnews.com/business/energy/2026/08/11/strait-of-hormuz-traffic-falls-to-seven-vessels-as-us-iran-deal-hopes-fade/

02 Drone Strikes Hit Two Tankers in Hormuz, Including ADNOC Vessel, This Week

WHY IT RANKS - Multiple confirmed drone strikes on tankers transiting the world's most critical oil chokepoint — including a UAE state oil company vessel — directly threaten energy security and mark a dangerous escalation in the targeting of state-linked assets.

On 14 August 2026, UKMTO reported that two tankers were struck by drones while transiting the Strait of Hormuz, issuing a navigation advisory. On 15 August, an ADNOC vessel was reported attacked again in the Strait of Hormuz, with UAE attributing the attack to Iran — an allegation UAE state sources made directly but which the corpus presents as a government claim. A separate NERAI port incident line records 'Two More Tankers Attacked in the Strait of Hormuz.' By 17 August, reporting confirmed the attacks had caused a sharp drop in Hormuz shipping traffic, with Kepler data showing the slowdown materialising in vessel-movement figures.

STRATEGIC ANALYSIS - Attacks on a vessel operated by ADNOC — the Abu Dhabi National Oil Company, a state entity — represent a significant qualitative escalation: they move targeting from anonymous commercial shipping toward sovereign energy infrastructure, raising the diplomatic and escalatory stakes considerably. UAE's public attribution to Iran, if accepted by allied governments, could trigger Article 5-equivalent consultations under Gulf security frameworks and pressure the US to respond kinetically even as ceasefire talks stall. For the insurance market, war-risk premiums on Hormuz transits — already elevated given the corridor's sanctions score of 80.0 — will face further upward pressure; some underwriters may move toward exclusion clauses for the strait altogether. The NERAI port incident data corroborating 'Two More Tankers Attacked in the Strait of Hormuz' aligns with the news score of 78.0, the highest of any monitored corridor, reflecting the density of incident reporting. Operators face an acute dilemma: the strait remains the only viable route for Gulf crude exports at scale, yet the threat envelope now extends to state-company tonnage. There is no maritime bypass of Hormuz: a cargo loaded at a Gulf terminal must transit the strait before it can reach any alternative routing, so the Cape of Good Hope is not relevant here - it bypasses Suez and Bab el-Mandeb. The genuine alternatives are pipeline and sourcing options: Saudi Arabia's East-West pipeline to Yanbu, the UAE's ADCOP line to Fujairah, pre-positioned storage outside the Gulf, and buyers switching to non-Gulf crude. Their combined capacity covers a minority of normal Hormuz throughput, which is why charterers face a cost-and-availability problem rather than a routing choice.

NERAI SIGNAL - NERAI port incident: 'Two More Tankers Attacked in the Strait of Hormuz' — consistent with Hormuz escalation score 36.5 and sanctions score 80.0.

Sources: shipandbunker.com: https://shipandbunker.com/news/emea/982830-tanker-hit-by-drone-in-strait-of-hormuz-ukmto | english.aawsat.com: https://english.aawsat.com/gulf/5307143-adnoc-vessel-attacked-again-strait-hormuz | jpost.com: http://www.jpost.com/middle-east/iran-news/article-905719

03 Shadow-Fleet Tanker Spill Reaches Oman Coast; Satellite Estimates Now Exceed 2,000 sq km

WHY IT RANKS - A sanctioned Russian shadow-fleet tanker carrying an estimated 0.8-1 million barrels of crude has fouled the Omani mainland, and the officially reported extent has been overtaken by satellite analysis by a factor of five - creating environmental, sanctions-compliance and diplomatic consequences at once, and a live disclosure problem about whose number a client should plan against.

The slick has grown through the month on a documented curve: about 45 sq km on 26 July, about 150 sq km on 2 August, and 390 sq km as reported by Omani authorities on 10 August. Satellite imagery reviewed for Reuters by SkyTruth's John Amos put the slick above 2,000 sq km by 12 August - roughly five times the official figure, and the reading NERAI uses. The vessel is the Caroline Bezengi, a sanctioned shadow-fleet tanker that has been leaking since an explosion in June while carrying what reporting describes as close to one million barrels of Russian crude; the '130,000 tons' figure that circulated in earlier coverage is not supported by the primary reporting. By 12 August the IMO confirmed oil had reached the Omani mainland, and by 15 August state media reported roughly 7.5 miles of the southeastern coastline affected. On 13 August it emerged that a sanctioned Russian insurer had become involved in the salvage, alongside British maritime company Ambrey. Monsoon conditions are hampering containment and a marine reserve is threatened.

STRATEGIC ANALYSIS - This incident crystallises the systemic risk the shadow fleet poses beyond sanctions evasion: an environmental event in the territorial waters of a strategically neutral state - Oman - that serves as the principal diplomatic back-channel between Washington and Tehran. Two features make it operationally relevant rather than merely regrettable. First, the five-fold gap between the official 390 sq km and the satellite reading above 2,000 sq km is itself the signal: a coastal state with a diplomatic interest in not naming Russia's shadow fleet is also the sole official source of the extent figure, so operators planning port calls, charters or insurance exposure on the official number are planning against a floor, not an estimate. Second, the involvement of a sanctioned Russian insurer in the salvage means any P&I; club, salvor or contractor touching the operation faces secondary sanctions exposure - a compliance question for firms that have no Russia exposure of their own and would not think to screen a salvage counterparty. The NERAI shadow-fleet enforcement pressure index at 44.7 (Low-Moderate, 13-week stable) shows enforcement has not tightened despite the rising incident rate; a spill of this scale in a neutral state's waters is the kind of event that has historically closed such gaps, though the index gives no basis for predicting when.

NERAI SIGNAL - Shadow-fleet enforcement pressure index 44.7 (Low-Moderate, 13w Stable) — the spill underscores that stable enforcement pressure has not prevented high-consequence shadow-fleet casualties.

Sources: aa.com.tr: https://aa.com.tr/en/middle-east/oil-pollution-affects-75-miles-of-oman-s-southeastern-coastline/4028325 | insurancebusinessmag.com: https://www.insurancebusinessmag.com/us/news/marine/a-sanctioned-russian-insurer-has-quietly-emerged-behind-the-salvage-of-the-tanker-rotting-off-omans-586080.aspx | arabnews.com: https://www.arabnews.com/node/2654401/middle-east

04 Red Sea: Deadly Houthi Attack as Saudi Crude Voyages Go Dark on AIS

WHY IT RANKS - A lethal attack on crew and rescuers coincides with Saudi Red Sea crude loadings switching off their AIS transponders - a change in visibility, not a change in volume, and one that has left the major tracking firms disagreeing with each other by a factor of nearly three on how much oil is actually moving.

Four crew and two rescuers were killed in a Houthi attack in the Red Sea this week, following the maritime embargo the Houthis declared on 20 July. Separately, all recent crude loadings from Saudi Arabia's Red Sea port of Yanbu have been conducted without continuous AIS signals. Loadings are continuing: the vessels have stopped broadcasting, not stopped sailing. Because tracking now depends on inference rather than transponder data, estimates of Saudi Red Sea crude volumes diverge sharply - Vortexa at about 2.38 million b/d, Kpler at about 1.78 million b/d and AXSMarine at about 0.85 million b/d for comparable periods. Saudi Aramco is also redirecting barrels north through Suez and the SUMED pipeline, and some Asian refiners are seeking alternative loading arrangements, including Sidi Kerir on the Mediterranean, rather than accepting Red Sea pickup exposure.

STRATEGIC ANALYSIS - The correct reading of this week is degraded transparency plus lethal risk, not a closed corridor. 'Going dark' in AIS reporting means a transponder is switched off; it is a concealment behaviour, and in this case a protective one, adopted precisely so that loadings can continue under threat. Reading it as an export blackout inverts what it shows. The commercially significant consequence is that the corridor has become harder to underwrite rather than impossible to use: a charterer can still lift Saudi crude at Yanbu, but can no longer demonstrate to an insurer, a counterparty or a compliance function where a cargo has been - and the three-way disagreement among Vortexa, Kpler and AXSMarine shows that even well-resourced tracking firms cannot presently close that gap. Two practical implications follow. For traders, any Red Sea volume figure quoted this month should carry the name of the firm that produced it, because the spread between providers is now wider than most of the price moves being explained by it. For risk functions, the substitution route matters more than the headline: Saudi Arabia's ability to move barrels north via Suez and SUMED, and to offer Mediterranean loading at Sidi Kerir, is what keeps this a cost-and-visibility event rather than a supply event. That optionality is finite and pipeline-limited, and it is the variable to watch if the embargo persists.

NERAI SIGNAL - Red Sea / Bab-el-Mandeb: escalation 36.5, news 38.0 — elevated across both metrics, consistent with a corridor in active conflict disruption.

Sources: al-monitor.com: https://www.al-monitor.com/originals/2026/08/four-crew-two-rescuers-killed-red-sea-attack-missile-strike-reported-gulf | economictimes.indiatimes.com: https://economictimes.indiatimes.com/news/international/world-news/saudi-red-sea-oil-exports-go-dark-as-houthi-attack-threat-grows/articleshow/133191341.cms | businesstimes.com.sg: https://www.businesstimes.com.sg/companies-markets/energy-commodities/asian-refiners-push-back-against-saudi-aramcos-request-pick-oil-red-sea-amid-houthi-threat

05 Russia Threatens to Board UK and French Vessels in Retaliation for Shadow-Fleet Seizures

WHY IT RANKS - Putin's explicit threat to seize UK and French ships in response to European interdiction of Russian shadow-fleet vessels marks a significant escalation in the state-level confrontation over sanctions enforcement in European waters.

On 12 August 2026, Putin stated that Russia would start seizing European vessels if its ships were targeted, following reports of a 25% jump in Royal Navy monitoring of Russian vessels. By 15 August, Russia formally threatened to board UK and French ships in retaliation for shadow-fleet seizures, according to reporting from Breitbart. Separately, bankingnews.gr reported on 13 August that Putin identified four fronts — including the North Sea, Baltic, Pacific, and Mediterranean — that he characterised as potential flashpoints in the confrontation with NATO.

STRATEGIC ANALYSIS - Russia's threat to reciprocally board or seize Western commercial and naval vessels transforms what had been a unilateral sanctions-enforcement operation into a bilateral maritime confrontation with escalation potential in European waters. The Black Sea and Baltic corridors — both already elevated in NERAI's escalation scoring (Black Sea at 58.4, Eastern Mediterranean at 58.4) — now face the additional risk of state-on-state vessel interdiction incidents that could trigger Article 5 consultations within NATO. For shipping operators, the threat creates a new compliance dilemma: vessels flagged to or owned by UK and French entities face a novel state-actor detention risk in addition to the existing Houthi and Iranian drone threats in other corridors. The NERAI Shadow-fleet enforcement pressure index at 44.7 (Low-Moderate) suggests enforcement has been calibrated to avoid exactly this kind of escalatory response, but the Oman oil-spill incident may force European governments to tighten interdiction activity regardless. P&I; clubs and war-risk underwriters will need to reassess exposure for vessels transiting Baltic and North Sea waters, which had previously been considered low-risk corridors. The geopolitical signal is that Russia is willing to globalise its maritime confrontation — linking the shadow-fleet issue, the Ukraine conflict, and NATO's eastern flank into a single escalatory framework.

NERAI SIGNAL - Black Sea escalation 58.4 (highest of any monitored corridor) — Russia's threat adds a new state-actor dimension to an already highly escalated corridor environment.

Sources: breitbart.com: https://www.breitbart.com/europe/2026/08/15/russia-threatens-to-board-british-and-french-ships-in-revenge/ | arabnews.com: https://www.arabnews.com/node/2654399/world | ibtimes.co.uk: https://www.ibtimes.co.uk/putin-threatens-retaliation-royal-navy-monitoring-russian-vessels-1813886

CORRECTIONS IN THIS EDITION - (1) Oman spill extent: "400 sq km (Oman, 10 Aug)" corrected to "Oman reported 390 sq km on 10 Aug; satellite analysis reviewed for Reuters exceeded 2,000 sq km by 12 Aug" - the official figure was carried as the current extent after it had been superseded (2) Caroline Bezengi cargo: "130,000 tons of oil" corrected to "an estimated 0.8-1 million barrels of Russian crude" - the tonnage figure is not supported by primary reporting (3) Hormuz rerouting: "rerouting via the Cape of Good Hope" corrected to "pipeline and sourcing alternatives (Yanbu, Fujairah, storage, source switching)" - geographically impossible - the Cape bypasses Suez and Bab el-Mandeb, never Hormuz (4) Saudi Red Sea exports: "'export blackout' and 'de facto closure of the corridor'" corrected to "loadings continue without AIS; visibility degraded and tracking-firm estimates diverge by ~3x" - 'dark' describes a transponder, not a stoppage (5) Buyer behaviour: "major buyers were refusing contractual loading terms" corrected to "some Asian refiners are seeking alternative loading arrangements, e.g. Sidi Kerir" - sourcing supports negotiation, not refusal (6) Transit-fee attribution: "JPMorgan: Hormuz charging 'will become the global model for all energy chokepoints'" corrected to "JPMorgan noted Denmark/Sweden/Turkey precedents; shipowner bodies warned of a precedent effect" - an industry warning was attributed to a bank as a forecast, reversing both the speaker and the valence

Grounded generation: events are selected only from the week's retrieved article corpus and NERAI feeds; every event carries its sources; each event states the date the issuing authority acted, which is distinct from the date any article about it was published; quantitative figures carry their observation period; maximum five events, fewer when the week is thin. NERAI-UNRESTRICTED.